Riboud, who headed Schlumberger for twenty years, was married to Rabindranath Tagore's niece. He was 'an articulate, elegant Frenchman and a Socialist whose closest friends included artists, writers and President Francois Mitterrand'. Ratan took long walks with him in his 1300-acre estate, La Carelle, in the East of France exchanging ideas and discussing varied topics. Through the interactions, Ratan was strongly influenced by the French icon.

Riboud had a 'surprising talent to avoid publicity'. Ratan is no different. Among the striking similarities they share is also their relentless pursuit of perfection. Riboud was often quoted as saying, 'It's easy to be the best … That's not enough. The goal is to strive for perfection.' Ratan's thought is no different.

Riboud had 'helped … Schlumberger, which had operated as a loose confederation of four family-owned companies, into a single entity'. Ratan did likewise, transforming the Tata Group from a loose confederation into a tightly bound, yet independent group of companies.

Valuing Human Relations

Almost everyone who has worked with Ratan swears by his commitment to the welfare of his friends and colleagues. Syamal Gupta narrated to me how, when he fell ill towards the end of 2018, Ratan called him up almost every day until he agreed to see a doctor. Without Ratan's persuasion and insistence, he may not have even gone to the hospital, Gupta said.

'He is incapable of ill-treating anyone. Not a single employee was unhappy with him,' says Sinha about the days Ratan spent in Jamshedpur as a trainee. Even when he became the chairman, Tata Sons, his attitude did not change.

Ishaat Hussain remarks, 'Ratan is very friendly, and amazingly humble. He was no different in 1992 [a full year after he had become chairman, Tata Sons] than when I saw him standing in the corner in 1982.' Even as chairman, Ratan could be seen at the wheel of a Maruti 1000, driving into the city with his dog. He would often stop to pick up Hussain, who was his neighbour at that time, and take him to the United Services (USO) club. He spoke as an equal with everyone, 'it was never a boss-subordinate conversation', says Hussain.